Show your evidence.

Name the problem. Give one number, with its source. Say who is affected. Propose one measure.

EDUCATOR IN A MEETING, A CONFERENCE OR A STAFF ROOM

A case in five moves

1. **One problem keeps coming up:** too many children are out of school.
   Name the problem. Start with the topic, not with the complaint.
2. **According to UNESCO,** 273 million children and young people are out of school.
   Give one number, with its source. The source goes first. Then the number.
3. **The hardest hit are** children in sub-Saharan Africa and in conflict zones.
   Say who is affected. A group of people, not a whole continent.
4. In Brazil, 27% of 15-year-olds reached the basic level in math, **compared with** about 70% across the OECD.
   Compare. Same test, same year, two groups.
5. **One option would be** to train more teachers, **but it would take** sustained investment.
   Propose one measure, and say its limit. A small proposal sounds more credible than a big promise.

TOO BLUNT, SAY THIS

Say the better version out loud first

~~Public schools are a disaster.~~	→	**Many public schools are struggling to deliver the basics.**
~~Teachers are paid nothing.~~	→	**Primary teachers earn slightly less than other professionals with similar qualifications.**
~~Governments don't care.~~	→	**Shrinking education budgets are part of the problem.**
~~Kids today can't even read.~~	→	**In low- and middle-income countries, about 7 in 10 ten-year-olds cannot read a simple text.**
~~Finland did it, so why can't we?~~	→	**Finland relies on trust and highly trained teachers. Could some of that travel?**

WHEN SOMEONE DISAGREES

Push back with evidence

1. **I see your point, but** the numbers suggest something else.
2. **That may be true in some countries.** In others, the problem is access.
3. **What does the evidence say** about that?
4. **Let's not compare apples with oranges.** Finland and Afghanistan start from very different places.
5. **Could you share the source?** I'd like to read it.

A REAL EXCHANGE

Two colleagues, two opinions

A Money is the whole problem. Fix the budget and schools will fix themselves.

B **Money matters, but** Finland's teachers are trained to master's level and trusted to teach.

A Finland is small and rich. Would that work in Brazil?

B **Fair point.** I'd take one idea, not the whole system: more time for teacher training.

Both speakers can be right. Say what you agree with before you add your point.

SAY THE NUMBERS

Out loud, in English

273 million	two hundred seventy-three million
2.2 million	two point two million
1 in 6	one in six
27%	twenty-seven percent
5.4%	five point four percent

Decimal point, thousands comma: 5,130.63. Not 5.130,63.

According to…
Never “according with”. Say “according to UNESCO”.

Million has no s.
273 million children. Never “273 millions of children”.

Fewer or less?
Fewer teachers, less money. Count it: fewer. Can't count it: less.

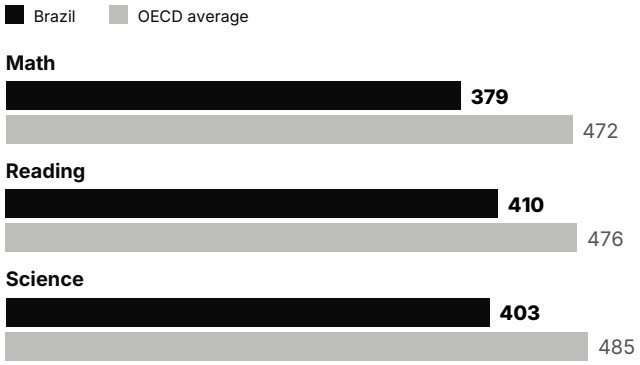
Compared with…
Brazil compared with the OECD average. Or “in comparison with”.

Four problems.

Access, learning, teachers and money. The same four show up in almost every country file.

THE FILE

Brazil and the OECD average · PISA 2022



Mean scores. OECD, PISA 2022 results.

NUMBERS YOU CAN QUOTE

With the source

273 million	children and young people are out of school. It is the seventh yearly rise in a row. UNESCO, Global Education Monitoring Report, 2026
44 million	primary and secondary teachers are missing worldwide, a deficit projected for 2030. UNESCO, Global Report on Teachers
7 in 10	ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries cannot read and understand a simple text. World Bank, UNICEF, UNESCO and others, 2022
2.2 million	Afghan girls are barred from secondary school. UNICEF and UNESCO, January 2026
47% vs 18%	Brazilian teachers who cite verbal abuse or intimidation as a source of stress, against the average of all participating countries. OECD, TALIS 2024, as reported by Education International and Gazeta do Povo
R$ 5,130.63	a month: the 2026 national pay floor for public school teachers in Brazil, for 40 hours a week. Agência Senado, 22 Jan 2026

COUNTRY FILES

One challenge, one fact

Sub-Saharan Africa	ACCESS	Particularly affected by exclusion from school, together with conflict zones.
Afghanistan	ACCESS	2.2 million girls are barred from secondary school under the Taliban.
Brazil	LEARNING	27% of students at level 2 or above in math, PISA 2022. OECD: about 70%.
Brazil	RESPECT	47% of teachers stressed by verbal abuse. TALIS average: 18%.
Finland	TEACHERS	A master's degree to teach in basic and secondary school. No classroom inspectors.
Viet Nam, Uzbekistan	STATUS	More than 70% of teachers feel valued by society. TALIS average: about 35%.

HOW POLICY PEOPLE SAY IT

Six terms and the sentence for the meeting

out-of-school children *n.*	"273 million children and young people are out of school."
learning poverty *n.*	"Learning poverty means a 10-year-old cannot read and understand a simple text."
teacher shortage *n.*	"UNESCO projects a deficit of 44 million teachers by 2030."
teacher attrition *n.*	"How do we keep attrition from emptying our schools?"
class size *n.*	"Smaller class size helps only if we have enough teachers."
per-pupil spending *n.*	"What is our per-pupil spending compared with the national average?"

STAFF ROOM TALK

Can you say it at a meeting?

Schools are falling apart.	👎 Say "Schools are under-resourced."
Kids are falling through the cracks.	👍 Common in education talk. Name the group: "Struggling readers are not getting support."
Teachers are burnt out.	👍 Fine. Add the cause: "Teachers are burnt out by admin work."
It's a broken system.	👎 Too much. "The system is not working for many students."
Teaching to the test.	👍 Standard phrase. "Teaching to the test narrows the curriculum."
Throwing money at the problem.	👎 A debate phrase, a bit sarcastic. "Funding alone will not fix this."

WATCH OUT · FALSE FRIENDS

The word looks Portuguese. It is not.

evaluation	~~I gave an evaluation on Friday.~~ → **I gave a test on Friday.** (an assessment). Evaluation = judging a program.
reprovar	~~He was reproved in math.~~ → **He failed math. / He repeated the year.** (Reprove = criticize.)
disciplina	~~Math is my favorite discipline.~~ → **Math is my favorite subject.** (Discipline = behavior.)
matrícula	~~Matriculation opens in January.~~ → **Enrollment opens in January.**
formação	~~teacher formation~~ → **teacher training** (Formation = shape.)
public school	~~In the UK: a public school is free.~~ → **In the UK, a public school is a private, fee-paying school.** (State school = free.)